Harbhajan bowls the second over of the day. I am facing. The first ball is floated and landing on off and middle. I reach forward and defend, head still, soft hands. There is no run. The next ball is also flighted. I watch it carefully and, turning the blade of the bat, prod the ball just wide of the crouching short leg.

This feels different. I have learned to play the ball so much later. I'm not forcing anything. I'm not trying to hit everything for four. I am letting the ball come to me. Is this happening? Each careful block feels so good. In fact, each careful block feels better than a boundary. At last, I feel in control.

Jacques and I continue to make progress, at the end of each over meeting in the middle of the pitch and chatting, keeping each other focused, keeping each other going. Jacques gets a break when a ball from Harbhajan rolls against a stump but doesn't dislodge the bail, and we take the total to 302 for four.

This is different. Sourav Ganguly is brought on to bowl the last over before the lunch interval. I am on 98. He's a part-time medium pacer. Keep concentrating, I tell myself. Don't give anything away. Don't take any risks. I walk across my stumps and shoulder arms to his first ball, and I leave the second ball as well.

The ball is not doing much. OK, get ready. This is it. I'm not going to enjoy my lunch if I'm stuck on 98. Let's get this over and done with right here, right now. I decide to paddle sweep the next delivery. I am premeditating, making up my mind on precisely what stroke I'm going to play before the ball has been bowled.

Ganguly bowls fractionally outside off stump. I shuffle across the crease, crouch down on one knee and manage to paddle the ball down to the fine leg boundary. The four runs bring up my fifth Test century, and I am overwhelmed by a sense of relief and satisfaction. OK, I tell myself, now carry on.

We bat on into the afternoon until Jacques plays on and is bowled by